

Beyond Entropy: Region Confidence Proxy for Wild Test-Time Adaptation

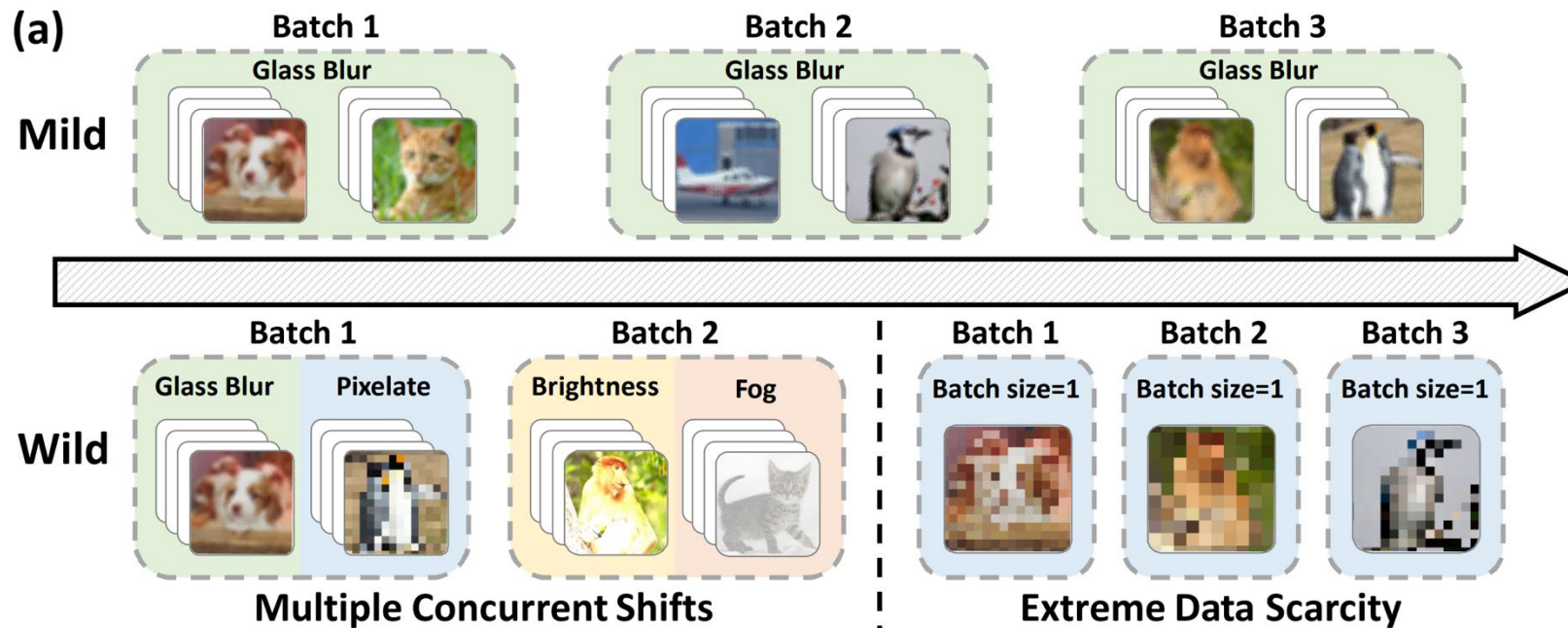
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Introduction

- TTA methods have achieved promising results under mild conditions
- But, they show significant performance drops in wild scenarios
 - focus on developing selection criteria to leverage reliable samples

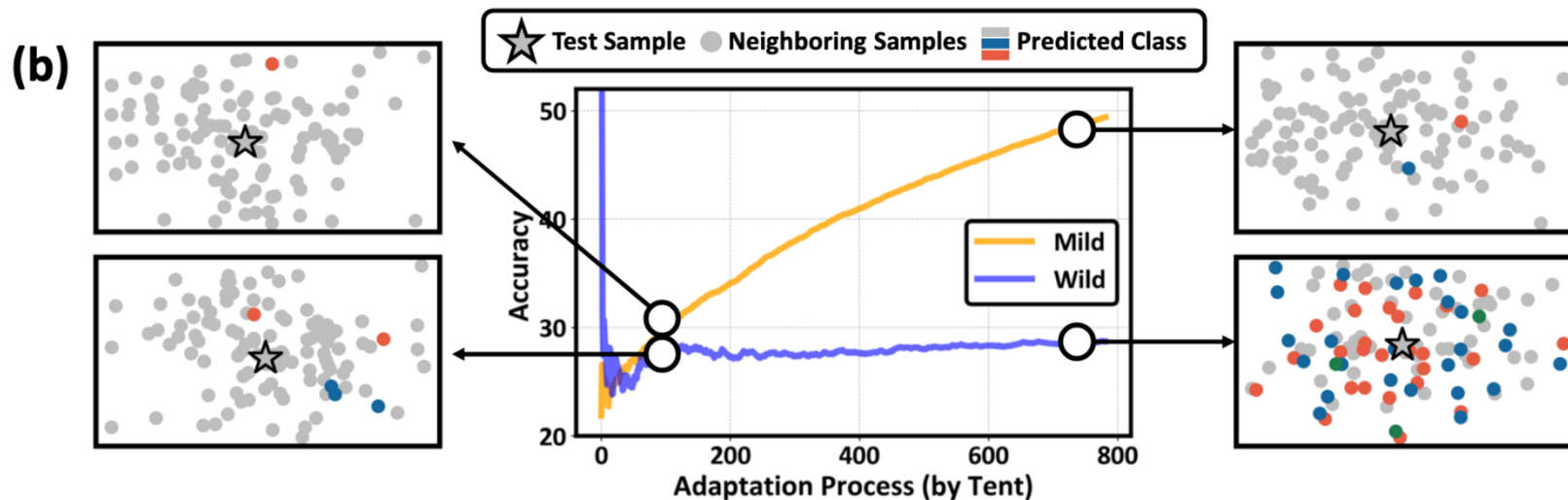


Introduction

- TTA methods have achieved promising results under mild conditions
- But, they show significant performance drops in wild scenarios
 - focus on developing selection criteria to leverage reliable samples
 - SAR (Niu et al., 2023) excluded samples with high entropy
 - DeYO (Lee et al., 2024) filtered out samples with sensitive prediction changes under image transformation
 - This paper aims to approach the more fundamental problem of entropy minimization
 - Not what to choose(criteria), but **what to minimize(objective)**

Introduction

- In wild scenes, we observe a notable instability in feature space
- Feature space should be grouped with samples that have semantically similar meanings
 - Enhance Region confidence



Preliminaries for Wild Test-Time Adaptation

- Practical Scenario in Wild TTA
 - Limited data stream: batch size = 1
 - Mixed testing domain: target domain consists of k different sub-domains
 - Imbalanced label shift: the test label distribution is imbalanced and shifts over time according to a function $Q_t(y)$
- Existing solutions: Entropy Minimization + selection criteria

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Exploring Entropy Minimization via Local Consistency

- EM's effectiveness heavily relies on the local consistency to extend sample-wise confidence to a regional scale
 - * Local consistency: nearby points share the similar prediction
 - local consistency
 - O: optimization for individual points align with the overall direction, magnifying the local effects
 - X: introducing noise that hinders adaptation in the affected region
- it is crucial to evaluate the reliability of entropy minimization in **preserving local consistency** under wild scenes.

Exploring Entropy Minimization via Local Consistency

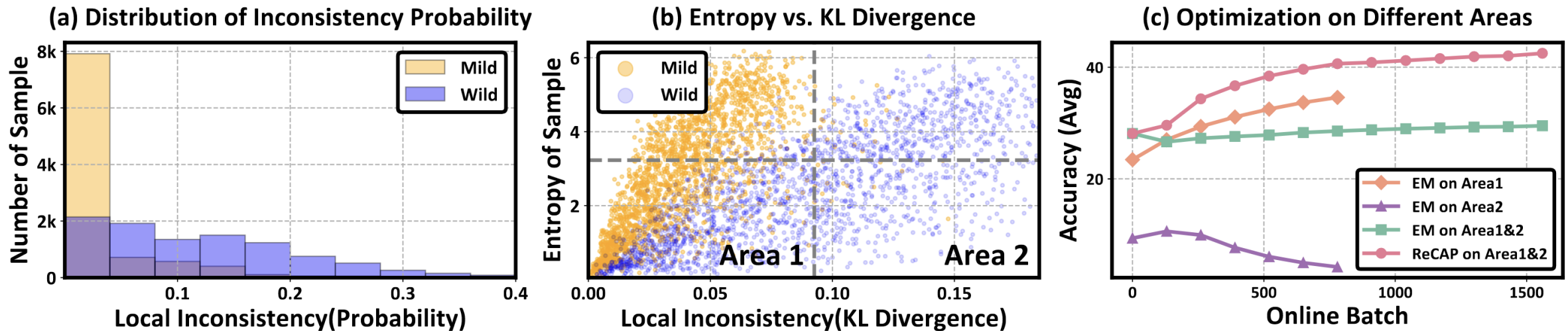


Figure 2. Local consistency during the entropy minimization process under mild and wild (imbalanced label shift) scenarios. Consistency is measured by prediction discrepancies between each sample and its 256 neighboring samples. (a) shows the probability of inconsistent predictions in neighbors. (b) records the entropy and average KL Divergence between prediction probabilities of samples and their neighbors. (c) investigates adaptation performance when using samples with varying levels of local consistency. All experiments are conducted on ImageNet-C of Gaussian noise with ResNet50. ‘EM’ denotes entropy minimization and ‘ReCAP’ denotes our method.

From Sample Confidence to Region Confidence

- Introduce a novel objective called **region confidence** to replace vanilla entropy
 - optimizes both region-wise confidence and stability simultaneously
 - improving global optimization efficiency
- Mathematical definition:

$$\mathcal{L}_{RC}(x) = \underbrace{\int_{\Omega} \mathcal{L}_{\text{ent}}(\tilde{x}) d\tilde{x}}_{\text{Bias term}} + \lambda \underbrace{\int_{\Omega} \mathcal{D}_{KL}(p_{\theta}(x) \| p_{\theta}(\tilde{x})) d\tilde{x}}_{\text{Variance term}},$$

Region Confidence Proxy

- There are still two considerable challenges to optimize region confidence
 1. Uncertain region scope
 - The static regions fix the sample location, making it difficult to determine an appropriate local scope
 2. Heavy computational burden
 - Previous term is intractable, relying on extensive sampling and additional model forwards for measurement
- Propose **Region Confidence Adaptive Proxy (ReCAP)**
 - Probabilistic region modeling mechanism
 - Efficient proxy for optimizing region confidence

Region Confidence Proxy

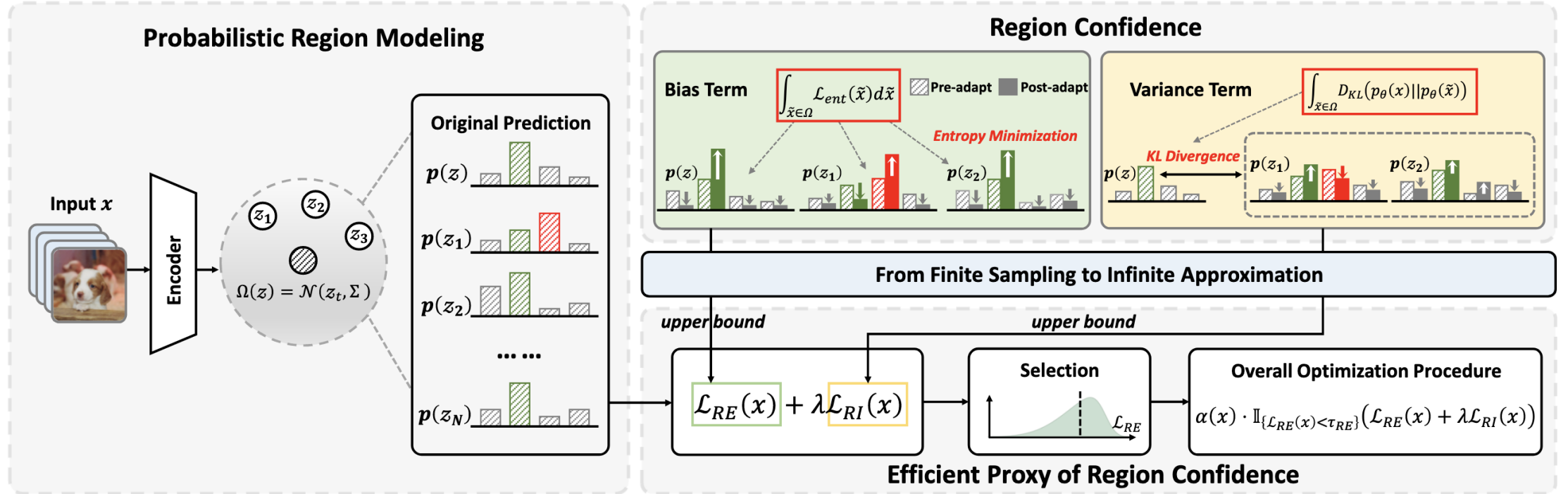


Figure 3. Overview of our ReCAP. ReCAP performs probabilistic modeling to determine local regions in the latent space (Sec. 4.1). We further derive two closed-form upper bounds for the intractable bias and variance terms via a finite-to-infinite asymptotic approximation, offering an efficient proxy for optimizing Region Confidence without the lengthy sampling process (Sec. 4.2 & 4.3).

Probabilistic Region Modeling

- Different directions in feature space can imply potentials of valuable semantic changes
 - Model local regions **in feature space** to flexibly capture rich semantic information
 - Select the latent space extracted by the backbone
 - Avoid class mixing
- Mathematical Definition

$$\mathcal{L}_{ent}(x) = -\boxed{p_{\theta}(x)} \cdot \log \boxed{p_{\theta}(x)} \rightarrow p_{\theta}(z)_i = (\text{softmax}(Az + b))_i = \frac{e^{a_i \cdot z + b_i}}{\sum_{j=1}^C e^{a_j \cdot z + b_j}},$$

- i : class
- $A \in \mathbb{R}^{C \times d}$ $b \in \mathbb{R}^C$: the linear and bias coefficients of the affine layer in the classifier

Probabilistic Region Modeling

- Local region as a static range -> a probabilistic representation following a **multivariate Gaussian distribution**

$$\Omega(z_t) := \mathcal{N}(z_t, \tau \cdot \Sigma), \Sigma = \text{Diag}(\text{Var}_{\mathcal{D}_S}(z))$$

- $\Omega(z_t)$: the local region of the t -th test batch z_t
- Σ : the diagonal matrix of variance on a small set of source data (e.g. 500 is enough)
- τ : a hyper-parameter to control the scope.

Efficient Metric of Region Confidence

- the computation of two terms
 - depends on an infinite number of potential samples from the distribution
 - requires extensive sampling to capture the statistical information
- Computational overhead and memory usage increase almost linearly with the number of sampling
- Approximation

Efficient Metric of Region Confidence

Lemma 4.1. (*Bias Term under Finite Sampling*) Given N features $z_1, \dots, z_N$ drawn from the local region and their corresponding probabilities: $p_\theta(z_1), \dots, p_\theta(z_N)$. The bias term on these features satisfies the following inequality:

$$\sum_{i=1}^N \mathcal{L}_{ent}(p_\theta(z_i)) \leq - \sum_{i=1}^C \frac{\sum_{k=1}^N p_\theta(z_k)_i}{N} \cdot \left(\sum_{j=1}^N \log p_\theta(z_j)_i \right), \quad (5)$$

Efficient Metric of Region Confidence

Lemma 4.2. (*Upper Bound of Negative Log-Likelihood*)

Given a feature z and its local region Ω which follows a Gaussian distribution $\mathcal{N}(\mu, \Sigma)$. The expected value of the logarithm of the predicted probability for the i -th class satisfies the following inequality:

$$\begin{aligned} & -\mathbb{E}_{z \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \Sigma)} \log p_{\theta}(z)_i \\ & \leq \log \sum_{j=1}^C e^{(a_j - a_i) \cdot \mu + (b_j - b_i) + \frac{1}{2} (a_j - a_i) \Sigma (a_j - a_i)^{\top}}, \end{aligned} \quad (6)$$

Efficient Metric of Region Confidence

- L_{RE} : Regional Entropy

Proposition 4.3. (Efficient Metric of Bias Term) *Given a feature z and its local region Ω which follows a Gaussian distribution $\mathcal{N}(\mu, \Sigma)$. The expectation of entropy loss over the entire distribution has a closed-form upper bound:*

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{E}_{\Omega}[\mathcal{L}_{ent}] &= -\mathbb{E}_{\tilde{z} \sim \mathcal{N}(z, \Sigma)} \sum_{i=1}^C p_{\theta}(\tilde{z})_i \log p_{\theta}(\tilde{z})_i \\ &\leq \sum_{j=1}^C \frac{e^{a_j \cdot z + b_j + \frac{1}{2} a_j \Sigma a_j^{\top}}}{\sum_{k=1}^C e^{a_k \cdot z + b_k + \frac{1}{2} a_k \Sigma a_k^{\top}}} \log \sum_{i=1}^C e^{(b_i - b_j)} \\ &\quad \cdot e^{(a_i - a_j) \cdot z + \frac{1}{2} (a_i - a_j) \Sigma (a_i - a_j)^{\top}} \triangleq \mathcal{L}_{RE} .\end{aligned}\tag{7}$$

Efficient Metric of Region Confidence

- L_{RI} : Regional Instability

Proposition 4.4. (Efficient Metric of Variance Term) *Given a feature z and its local region Ω which follows a Gaussian distribution $\mathcal{N}(\mu, \Sigma)$. The expectation of Kullback-Leibler divergence between the output probability over this distribution and the probability at its center has an upper bound:*

$$\begin{aligned} & E_{\tilde{z} \sim \mathcal{N}(z, \Sigma)} KL(p_{\theta}(z) \| p_{\theta}(\tilde{z})) \\ & \leq \sum_{j=1}^C \frac{e^{a_j \cdot z + b_j}}{\sum_{k=1}^C e^{a_k \cdot z + b_k}} \cdot \log \sum_{i=1}^C \frac{e^{a_i \cdot z + b_i}}{\sum_{k=1}^C e^{a_k \cdot z + b_k}} \quad (8) \\ & \cdot e^{\frac{1}{2}(a_i - a_j) \Sigma (a_i - a_j)^{\top}} \triangleq \mathcal{L}_{RI}, \end{aligned}$$

Overall Procedure of ReCAP

$$\min_{\theta} \alpha(x) \cdot \mathbb{I}_{\{\mathcal{L}_{RE}(x) < \tau_{RE}\}} (\mathcal{L}_{RE}(x) + \lambda \mathcal{L}_{RI}(x)),$$
$$\text{where } \alpha(x) \triangleq \frac{1}{\exp(\mathcal{L}_{RE}(x) - \mathcal{L}_0)}, \quad (9)$$

Overall Procedure of ReCAP

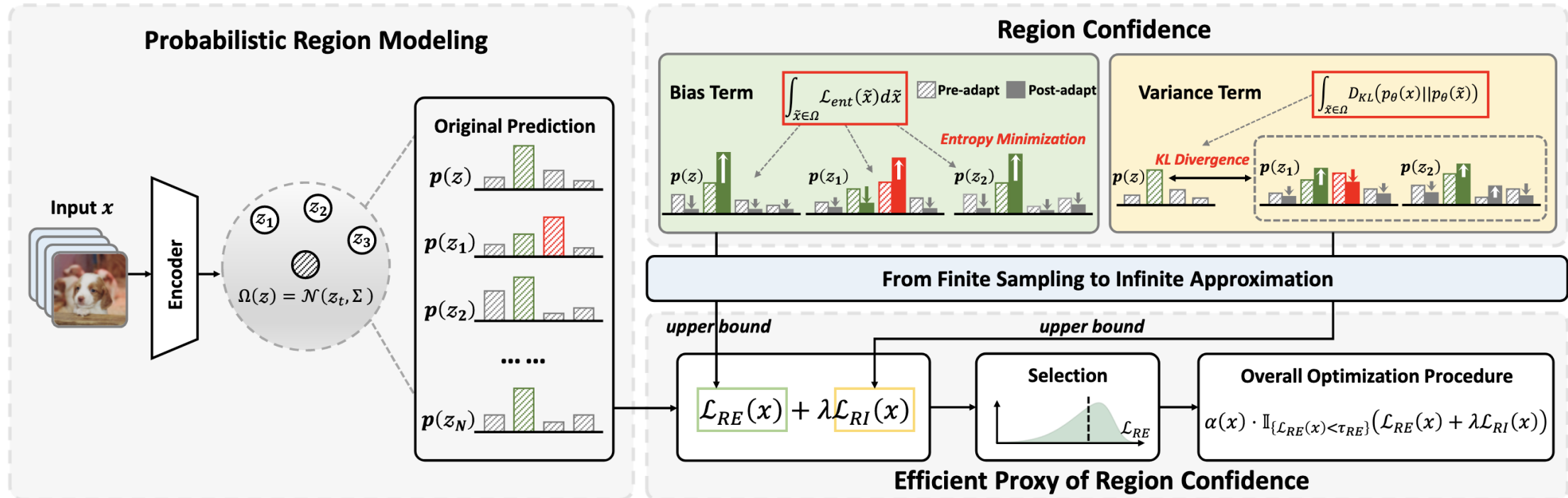


Figure 3. Overview of our ReCAP. ReCAP performs probabilistic modeling to determine local regions in the latent space (Sec. 4.1). We further derive two closed-form upper bounds for the intractable bias and variance terms via a finite-to-infinite asymptotic approximation, offering an efficient proxy for optimizing Region Confidence without the lengthy sampling process (Sec. 4.2 & 4.3).

Ablation studies

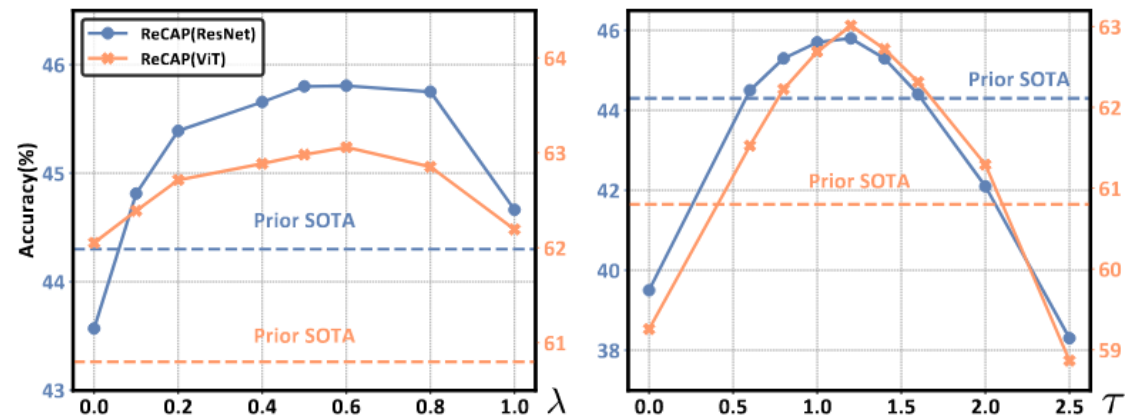


Figure 4. (a) Performance with varying strengths λ of the variance term. (b) Performance with different ranges τ of the local region.

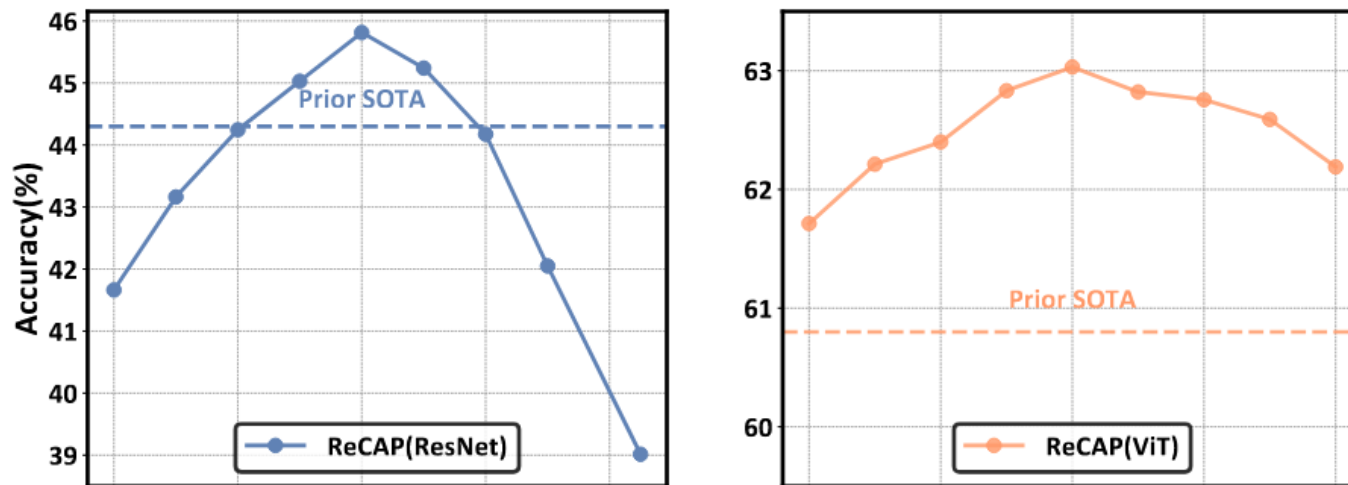


Figure 7. Performance under different selection boundary τ_{RE} for ResNet and ViT on ImageNet-C under label shifts.

Ablation studies

Table 7. Effects of components in ReCAP. For a fair comparison, ‘+Vanilla Entropy’ uses entropy-based selection and weighting.

Vanilla Entropy	Component		Corruption Category				Average
	$\mathcal{L}_{RE}$ in Eq. 7	$\mathcal{L}_{RI}$ in Eq. 8	Noise	Blur	Weather	Digital	
✓			24.9	19.6	41.5	37.8	31.4
	✓		41.9	29.9	56.4	44.5	43.3
✓		✓	41.3	26.8	55.0	47.3	42.7
	✓	✓	42.9	31.0	57.1	51.2	45.8

Experiments

Table 1. Comparisons with state-of-the-art methods on ImageNet-C (severity level 5) under **Limited Batch Size = 1** regarding Accuracy (%). We report mean performance over 3 independent runs. The best results are in bold and the second-best are in underline.

Model+Method	Noise			Blur				Weather				Digital				Average
	Gauss.	Shot	Impul.	Defoc.	Glass	Motion	Zoom	Snow	Frost	Fog	Brit.	Contr.	Elastic	Pixel	JPEG	
ResNet50	18.0	19.8	17.9	19.8	11.4	21.4	24.9	40.4	47.3	33.6	69.3	36.3	18.6	28.4	52.3	30.6
• MEMO	18.5	20.5	18.4	17.1	12.6	21.8	26.9	40.4	47.0	34.4	69.5	36.5	19.2	32.1	53.3	31.2
• DDA	42.4	43.3	42.3	16.6	19.6	21.9	26.0	35.7	40.1	13.7	61.2	25.2	37.5	46.6	54.1	35.1
• Tent	2.5	2.9	2.5	13.5	3.6	18.6	17.6	15.3	23.0	1.4	70.4	42.2	6.2	49.2	53.8	21.5
• EATA	24.9	28.0	25.8	18.3	17.0	31.2	29.8	42.5	44.1	41.3	70.9	44.2	27.6	46.8	55.4	36.5
• SAR	25.5	28.0	24.9	18.7	16.3	28.6	31.4	46.2	44.9	33.4	72.8	44.3	15.3	47.1	56.1	35.6
• DeYO	41.2	44.3	42.5	22.4	24.7	41.8	21.9	54.8	51.6	21.9	73.1	53.2	48.5	59.8	59.6	44.1
• ReCAP (Ours)	42.5	44.4	42.9	19.4	25.0	42.2	44.0	49.7	52.4	57.5	72.9	53.6	29.5	60.4	60.0	46.4
• ReCAP+SAR	41.7	<u>44.5</u>	40.6	<u>24.8</u>	<u>25.8</u>	44.0	47.0	56.2	53.0	<u>52.8</u>	<u>73.4</u>	<u>54.6</u>	<u>48.8</u>	61.7	60.7	<u>48.6</u>
• ReCAP+DeYO	42.5	44.8	<u>42.8</u>	25.9	27.2	<u>43.7</u>	<u>44.9</u>	<u>55.8</u>	<u>52.8</u>	51.9	73.5	54.8	50.9	<u>61.5</u>	60.7	48.9
Vitbase	9.5	6.7	8.2	29.0	23.4	33.9	27.1	15.9	26.5	47.2	54.7	44.1	30.5	44.5	47.8	29.9
• MEMO	21.6	17.3	20.6	37.1	29.6	40.4	34.4	24.9	34.7	55.1	64.8	54.9	37.4	55.4	57.6	39.1
• DDA	41.3	41.1	40.7	24.4	27.2	30.6	26.9	18.3	27.5	34.6	50.1	32.4	42.3	52.2	52.6	36.1
• Tent	42.2	1.0	43.3	52.4	48.2	55.5	50.5	16.5	16.9	66.4	74.9	64.7	51.6	67.0	64.3	47.7
• EATA	30.1	24.6	34.2	44.3	39.6	48.4	42.4	38.1	46.0	60.7	65.8	61.2	46.7	57.8	59.5	46.6
• SAR	42.7	39.5	41.9	54.6	51.2	58.3	54.4	60.2	54.7	70.3	75.9	66.8	58.4	69.5	66.3	57.6
• DeYO	53.4	50.4	55.0	58.7	59.5	64.5	52.5	68.1	66.3	73.8	78.3	<u>67.9</u>	68.9	73.8	70.8	64.1
• ReCAP (Ours)	53.5	56.7	56.9	59.2	60.5	<u>65.3</u>	64.0	<u>69.6</u>	67.2	<u>74.1</u>	<u>78.4</u>	64.6	70.2	<u>74.4</u>	<u>71.5</u>	65.7
• ReCAP+SAR	55.3	<u>56.2</u>	<u>56.5</u>	60.0	61.2	66.5	65.2	69.8	68.0	74.5	78.6	68.4	71.0	74.9	71.6	66.5
• ReCAP+DeYO	<u>54.4</u>	55.3	55.5	<u>59.8</u>	<u>61.1</u>	65.2	<u>64.9</u>	69.3	<u>67.9</u>	73.9	<u>78.4</u>	67.1	<u>70.7</u>	<u>74.4</u>	71.0	<u>65.9</u>

Table 2. Comparisons with SOTA methods on ImageNet-C (severity level 5, 4) under **Mixed Testing Domain**.

Model+Method	Level=5	Level=4	Average
ResNet50	30.6	42.7	36.7
• MEMO	31.2	43.0	37.1
• DDA	35.1	43.6	39.4
• Tent	13.4	20.6	17.0
• EATA	38.1	47.7	42.9
• SAR	38.3	48.6	43.5
• DeYO	38.6	50.2	44.4
• ReCAP (Ours)	41.5	51.2	46.4
• ReCAP+SAR	<u>42.1</u>	<u>51.9</u>	<u>47.0</u>
• ReCAP+DeYO	42.2	52.4	47.3
VitBase	29.9	42.9	36.4
• MEMO	39.1	51.3	45.2
• DDA	36.1	45.1	40.6
• Tent	16.5	64.3	40.4
• EATA	55.7	63.7	59.7
• SAR	57.1	64.9	61.0
• DeYO	59.4	66.8	63.1
• ReCAP (Ours)	59.4	<u>67.1</u>	63.3
• ReCAP+SAR	60.0	67.2	63.6
• ReCAP+DeYO	<u>59.8</u>	67.0	<u>63.4</u>

Experiments

Table 3. Comparisons with state-of-the-art methods on ImageNet-C (severity level 5) under **Imbalanced Label Shift**.

Model+Method	Noise			Blur				Weather				Digital				Average
	Gauss.	Shot	Impul.	Defoc.	Glass	Motion	Zoom	Snow	Frost	Fog	Brit.	Contr.	Elastic	Pixel	JPEG	
ResNet50	17.9	19.9	17.9	19.7	11.3	21.3	24.9	40.4	47.4	33.6	69.2	36.3	18.7	28.4	52.2	30.6
• MEMO	18.4	20.6	18.4	17.1	12.7	21.8	26.9	40.7	46.9	34.8	69.6	36.4	19.2	32.2	53.4	31.3
• DDA	42.5	43.4	42.3	16.5	19.4	21.9	26.1	35.8	40.2	13.7	61.3	25.2	37.3	46.9	54.3	35.1
• Tent	2.6	3.3	2.7	13.9	7.9	19.5	28.7	16.5	21.9	1.8	70.5	42.2	6.6	49.4	53.7	22.8
• EATA	27.2	28.5	28.4	15.1	16.7	24.6	25.5	32.5	32.2	40.0	66.5	33.2	24.1	42.2	38.6	31.7
• SAR	34.0	36.7	36.2	21.8	20.9	33.2	32.4	38.7	45.6	50.6	72.9	46.8	14.3	52.2	56.8	39.5
• DeYO	41.7	44.0	42.5	23.4	23.9	41.3	13.0	<u>53.9</u>	<u>52.2</u>	<u>38.6</u>	<u>73.1</u>	52.3	<u>46.8</u>	59.3	59.1	44.3
• ReCAP (Ours)	42.0	44.1	<u>42.7</u>	19.8	<u>24.3</u>	39.7	<u>40.2</u>	46.0	52.2	<u>57.3</u>	<u>73.1</u>	52.4	33.7	59.4	<u>59.5</u>	45.8
• ReCAP+SAR	42.2	<u>44.4</u>	<u>42.7</u>	<u>24.1</u>	<u>24.3</u>	<u>41.6</u>	43.8	51.6	<u>52.4</u>	56.8	<u>73.1</u>	<u>52.9</u>	38.9	<u>60.2</u>	59.4	<u>47.2</u>
• ReCAP+DeYO	42.5	44.5	43.3	25.8	26.7	43.3	39.1	54.2	53.2	59.3	73.4	53.8	49.2	61.4	60.3	48.7
Vitbase	9.4	6.7	8.3	29.1	23.4	34.0	27.0	15.8	26.3	47.4	54.7	43.9	30.5	44.5	47.6	29.9
• MEMO	21.6	17.4	20.6	37.1	29.6	40.6	34.4	25.0	34.8	55.2	65.0	54.9	37.4	55.5	57.7	39.1
• DDA	41.3	41.3	40.6	24.6	27.4	30.7	26.9	18.2	27.7	34.8	50.0	32.3	42.2	52.5	52.7	36.2
• Tent	32.7	1.4	34.6	54.4	52.3	58.2	52.2	7.7	12.0	69.3	76.1	66.1	56.7	69.4	66.4	47.3
• EATA	35.8	34.8	36.8	45.1	47.3	49.3	47.8	56.6	55.5	62.1	72.3	21.6	56.0	64.6	63.7	50.0
• SAR	48.2	<u>48.7</u>	49.0	55.4	54.5	59.2	54.3	55.8	54.5	70.0	76.9	66.1	62.2	70.2	66.5	59.4
• DeYO	53.0	34.4	48.8	<u>57.6</u>	58.5	63.3	35.4	67.4	66.0	<u>73.0</u>	77.7	66.6	68.1	73.1	<u>69.8</u>	60.8
• ReCAP (Ours)	<u>53.1</u>	38.5	49.6	<u>57.3</u>	59.0	63.8	<u>60.7</u>	67.8	<u>66.3</u>	72.9	77.7	66.8	68.2	73.0	70.0	63.0
• ReCAP+SAR	53.2	42.7	<u>50.9</u>	58.0	<u>58.9</u>	63.8	60.9	67.6	66.1	73.2	77.6	67.6	68.3	73.1	<u>69.8</u>	<u>63.4</u>
• ReCAP+DeYO	<u>53.1</u>	53.9	54.1	57.4	58.8	63.6	60.6	67.8	66.4	72.9	77.7	<u>67.1</u>	68.3	73.1	<u>69.8</u>	64.3

Experiments

Model+Method	Limited Batch Size = 1			Imbalanced Label Shift			Average
	ResNet	VitBase	Avg	ResNet	VitBase	Avg	
No-Adapt Model	40.8	43.1	42.0	40.8	43.1	42.0	42.0
• Tent (Wang et al., 2020)	43.2	43.8	43.5	42.4	46.8	44.6	44.1
• EATA (Niu et al., 2022)	44.1	52.5	48.3	42.1	50.5	46.3	47.3
• SAR (Niu et al., 2023)	46.7	55.5	51.1	44.3	54.4	49.4	50.2
• DeYO (Lee et al., 2024)	48.1	59.2	53.7	46.7	58.5	52.6	53.1
• ReCAP (Ours)	51.5 ± 0.5	61.1 ± 0.6	56.3 ± 0.5	49.6 ± 0.2	60.4 ± 0.2	55.0 ± 0.2	55.7 ± 0.4

Table 5. Comparisons with state-of-the-art methods on **ImageNet-R** under **Limited Batch Size = 1** & **Imbalanced Label Shift** regarding Accuracy (%). We report mean&std over 3 independent runs. The best results are in bold.

Model+Method	Limited Batch Size = 1			Imbalanced Label Shift			Average
	ResNet	VitBase	Avg	ResNet	VitBase	Avg	
No-Adapt Model	43.5	44.3	43.9	43.5	44.3	43.9	43.9
• Tent (Wang et al., 2020)	43.9	50.6	47.3	43.7	50.1	46.9	47.1
• EATA (Niu et al., 2022)	44.2	49.5	46.9	43.5	51.6	47.6	47.2
• SAR (Niu et al., 2023)	45.2	52.8	49.0	44.7	53.9	49.3	49.2
• DeYO (Lee et al., 2024)	45.8	58.5	52.2	45.2	57.1	51.2	51.7
• ReCAP (Ours)	48.0 ± 0.2	59.2 ± 0.9	53.6 ± 0.6	47.7 ± 0.2	58.5 ± 0.6	53.1 ± 0.4	53.4 ± 0.5

Table 6. Comparisons with state-of-the-art methods on **VisDA-2021** under **Limited Batch Size = 1** & **Imbalanced Label Shift** regarding Accuracy (%). We report mean&std over 3 independent runs. The best results are in bold.

Experiments

Table 4. Efficiency comparison of various methods. We assess TTA approaches for processing 50,000 images in Gaussian corruption type, using a single Nvidia RTX 4090 GPU.

Method	Forward	Backward	Other computation	Time
No-adapt	50,000	N/A	N/A	84s
DDA	-	-	Diffusion model	13,277s
Tent	50,000	50,000	N/A	110s
EATA	50,000	19,608	regularizer	118s
SAR	66,418	30,488	Model updates	164s
DeYO	82,843	24,714	Data augmentation	144s
ReCAP	50,000	19,512	Eq. 9	116s

Experiments

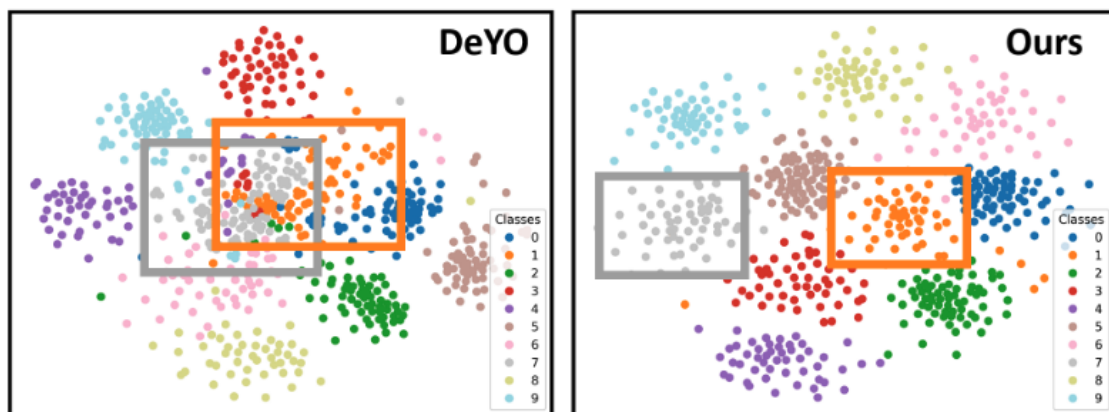


Figure 5. The t-SNE visualization of feature space in Snow corruption type after model adaptation.

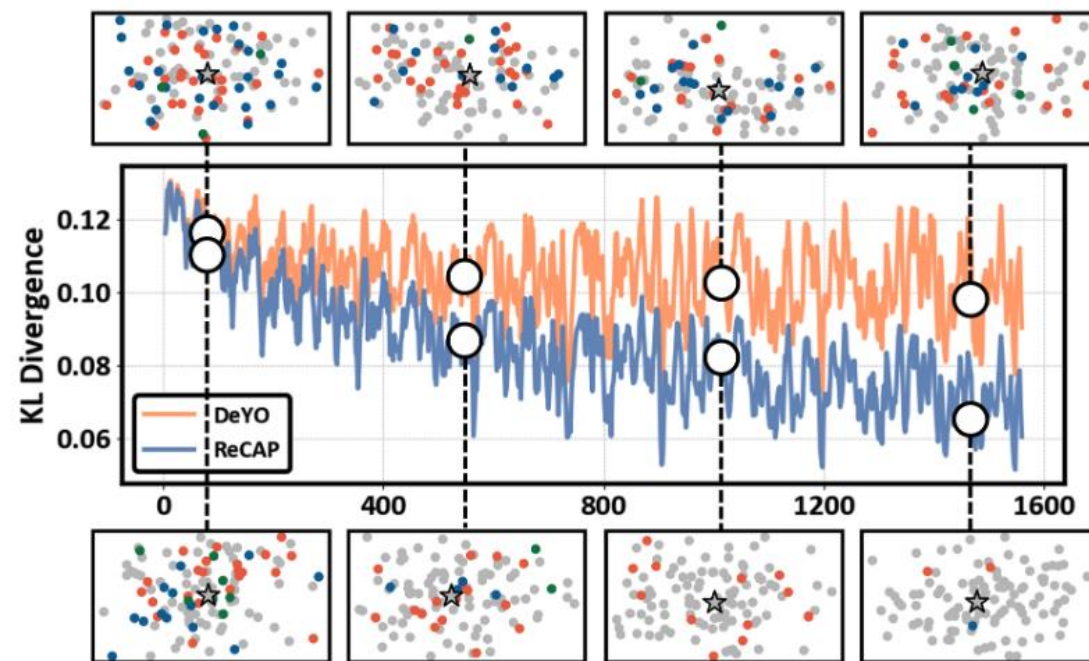


Figure 6. Visualization of prediction results and KL Divergence of prediction probabilities in local region. Different colors of points represent different predicted classes of samples within the region.

Experiments

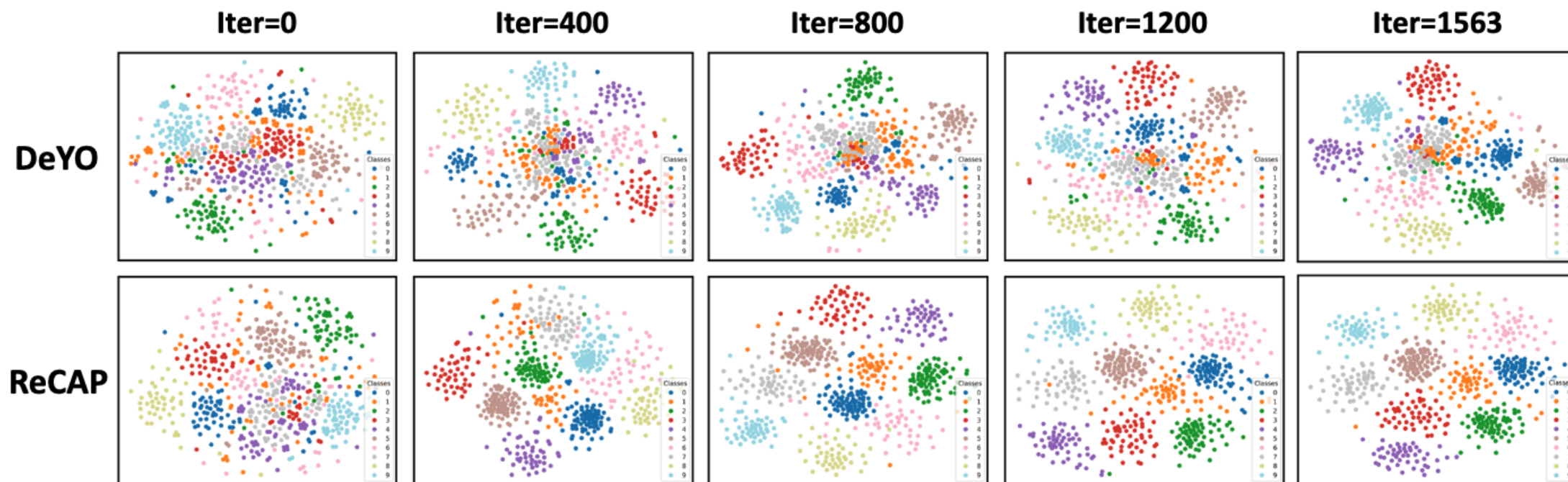


Figure 8. The evolution of feature space under DeYO and ReCAP methods. The visualizations are conducted on ImageNet-C under label shift scenario with ResNet50.

Thank You!